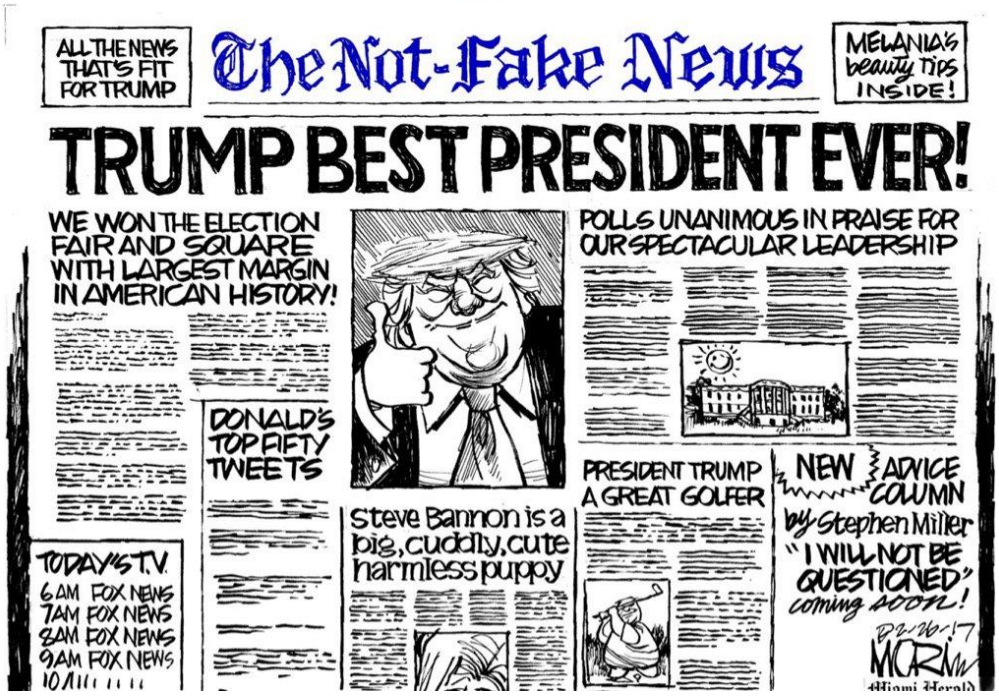
Fake News and the Spread of Misinformation





1- Discuss about the following questions with your partner

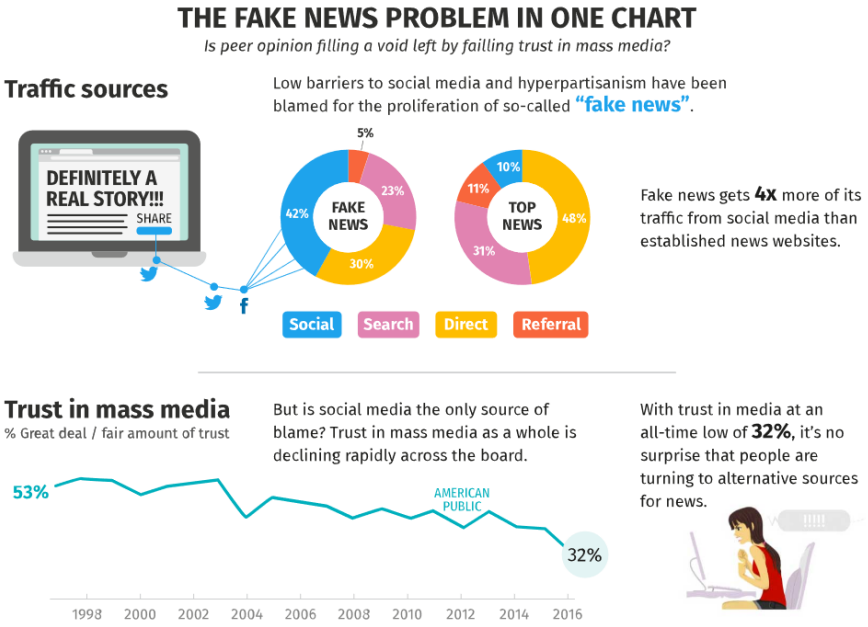
a. A- What is news?
b. Where do you get your news from?
c. How important is keeping up to date with the news to you?
d. Do you prefer to watch, listen to or read about news?
e. What areas of the world are you most interested in?
f. What kinds of stories hit the headlines in your local newspaper?
g. What news story are you following at the moment?
h. Do you trust everything you read, see or hear on the news?
i. What are factcheckers ?
j. Comment on the cartoons above .

FAKE NEWS

2- Can you give a complete definition of the word “Fake news “ ? In the light of current events , why is it very important ?

3- Do you agree with Wikipedia definition :

Fake news "is a type of hoax or deliberate spread of misinformation, be it via the traditional news media or via social media, with the intent to mislead in order to gain financially or politically. It often employs eye-catching headlines or entirely fabricated news-stories in order to increase readership and online sharing. Profit is made in a similar fashion to clickbait and relies on ad-revenue generated regardless of the veracity of the published stories. Easy access to ad-revenue, increased political polarization and the ubiquity of social media, primarily the Facebook newsfeed have been implicated in the spread of fake news. Anonymously hosted websites lacking known publishers have also been implicated, because they make it difficult to prosecute sources of fake news for slander.]"
(Wikipedia)



4- Watch the videos :

https://ed.ted.com/lessons/how-to-choose-your-news-damon-brown

https://www.youtube.com/watch?time_continue=23&v=cSKGa_7XJkg

Answer the questions :

- “ How to choose your news ? “ (give 5 tips at least)



- So-called "citizen journalism" has exploded as smartphones, glasses-based cameras, and other tools make it easier for average people to report breaking news. What are some of the positives and negatives with citizen journalism?

5- Read the following newspaper article and answer the questions :

Google to display fact-checking labels to show if news is true or false

In its ongoing bid to combat fake news, Google follows Facebook in announcing new technology to help curb spread of misinformation

Samuel Gibbs

Fri 7 Apr 2017 16.37 BST Last modified on Tue 28 Nov 2017 02.24 GMT

Google's fact-checking feature was introduced to Google News in UK and US in October, but will now be displayed globally.

Google is to start displaying fact-checking labels in its search results to highlight news and information that has been vetted and show whether it is considered to be true or false, as part of its efforts to help combat the spread of misinformation and fake news.

The fact-checking feature, which was first introduced to Google News in the UK and US in October, will now be displayed as an information box in general search results as well as news search results globally.

The small snippets display information about the claim made by a particular page or site and who made the claim, as well as the results of fact checking on the highlighted claim. The fact checks are not performed by Google, but by named trusted publishers and fact-checkers using an open system to mark claims as having been checked.

Cong Yu from Google and Justin Kosslyn from fact-check partner Jigsaw said: "With thousands of new articles published online every minute of every day, the amount of content confronting people online can be overwhelming. And unfortunately, not all of it is factual or true, making it hard for people to distinguish fact from fiction.

"As we make fact checks more visible in search results, we believe people will have an easier time reviewing and assessing these fact checks, and making their own informed opinions."

Fact check boxes will not be displayed for every search result, and only publishers that are "algorithmically determined to be an authoritative source of information" will be included in the program Google said.

The expansion comes in the wake of heavy criticism of US technology firms for their inaction over the spread of misinformation and fake news, particularly around high-profile topics such as the US election. The UK government recently urged US firms, including Google, Facebook, Twitter and Microsoft, to do more to police their platforms and remove illegal and extremist content.

German chancellor Angela Merkel's cabinet has also backed legislation that could lead to fines of up to €50m if social networks refuse to remove illegal content and don't give users an effective way to report fake news and hate speech.

The spread of false information is not a new problem, but has been amplified by the ease of publishing and the vast reach provided by search engines and expansive social networks. The barrier to entry is small and the volume of content high, leading to an expanding issue across multiple platforms and outlets.

Research from the Reuters Institute for the Study of Journalism in June 2016 found that Facebook was the primary news source for 18-to-24-year-olds. In August, the social network site became embroiled in a



fake news storm after sacking editorial staff controlling its trending topics news feed, replacing it with an algorithm that began promoting fake news.
Facebook recently began trialling a third-party fact-checking tool that flags stories shared on the social media site as "disputed" by named fact checkers, including Snopes.com and the Associated Press.
On Thursday Facebook also published a tool it hoped would help educate the public on how to spot fake news and how discern trustworthy sources from those spreading false information. Facebook users will be presented with a large post at the top of their News Feeds with 10 tips for identifying misinformation including being sceptical about headlines that make shocking claims.

a- Summarize the main ideas of the text in 3 sentences maximum)
b- How do companies like Facebook or Google intend to fight against the spreading of misinformation?
c- What does the German Counsellor intend to do if social networks refuse to remove illegal content?
d- Why is it so difficult to handle fake news?
e- Which scandal was Facebook involved in?
f- How does Facebook try to 'educate' the public on how to spot fake news?
g- Explain what a fact checker is. Why is it essential that these people work with social media ? Write a constructed essay in which you will develop your argument and illustrate with relevant examples .

6- Read the following article and summarize its main content .

By Dana Milbank
November 18, 2016

ABuzzFeed analysis this week concluded that fake news stories about the election generated more engagement on Facebook than the top election stories from 19 major news outlets — combined.

And that's not the half of it.

Not only is fake news getting more attention than actual news, but also the leading purveyor of fake news in the United States is now the president-elect.

For 17 months, Donald Trump treated the nation to a series of outlandish promises. He'll eliminate the $19 trillion federal debt in eight years. He'll balance the budget without cutting Social Security, Medicare



and other entitlements. He'll bring back lost coal jobs. He'll make Mexico pay for a border wall. He'll deport 12 million illegal immigrants while growing the economy by at least 6 percent.

Now Trump is the president-elect, and it's time to deliver on the impossible. No wonder his transition is racked with chaos and infighting. Scripture tells us you can't serve both God and mammon. Yet Trump proposes to be served by both Reince Priebus and Stephen K. Bannon — a chief of staff who is a paragon of the establishment and a top adviser who is a leading voice for white supremacists. The array of impossible promises and false claims has all the appearances of a Ponzi scheme, with the $18 trillion U.S. economy in the balance. Bernie Madoff's scheme lost only $50 billion.

Early indications are that Trump plans to continue to fake it. On Thursday night, he tweeted that as a result of his work with Ford, the automaker would keep a plant that makes Lincoln SUVs "in Kentucky — no [sic] Mexico."

But Ford had never planned to close the Kentucky plant. It was merely planning to make more Ford Escapes instead of Lincolns there — a change that would have resulted in no job losses. Ford is proceeding with its previously announced plan to build a new factory in Mexico.

We see the Ponzi scheme unraveling in the substance of what Trump is proposing, too. One of Trump's surrogates, Carl Higbie, caused a furor this week by saying the infamous internment of U.S. citizens and noncitizens of Japanese descent during World War II provided a legal "precedent" for Trump's plan to create a Muslim registry. But for all the outrage Higbie caused, the actual policy being floated — reinstatement of a George W. Bush-era policy — is far more modest than Trump's proposed ban on Muslim immigration and threat to register American Muslims.

This is the best-case scenario — that Trump's fake-news presidential campaign really was all a con. Preposterous promises give way to modest proposals. This would disappoint his supporters, but perhaps save the country.

Trump's vow that Carrier would reverse its plans to move a factory to Mexico and eliminate 1,400 U.S. jobs by 2019? Carrier is continuing with its plans.

Trump's promise to negotiate the release of all American prisoners in Iran before taking office? He'd better hurry: Iran continues to apprehend and imprison American dual nationals.

Trump's bold threats to appoint a "killer" ambassador to Japan and to force Japan to pay for U.S. military protection? Japanese Prime Minister Shinzo Abe, after visiting Trump on Thursday, thinks otherwise; he said he has "great confidence" in Trump.

Many of Trump's absurd promises will come due soon. Trump spoke of abolishing the Education Department and the Environmental Protection Agency, said he would rebuild American roads for one-third the current price, monitor mosques, prosecute Hillary Clinton and never take a vacation. He said he would spend no money on space exploration before infrastructure is repaired, would "bomb the s--- out of" the Islamic State, kill the relatives of terrorists, shut down parts of the Internet, reinstate waterboarding, dramatically increase tariffs, eliminate Wall Street reforms, cut the budget 20 percent and end birthright citizenship.



No surprise that the transition is chaotic. Lobbyists are in, then out. Chris Christie and Mike Rogers are in, then out. Frank Gaffney is in, or perhaps not. Jared Kushner is settling personal vendettas. Eliot Cohen withdraws his cooperation, predicting "ugly" things ahead.

And Trump says everything is proceeding "so smoothly."

The British are fuming because at least nine foreign leaders, including Egypt's, reached Trump before theirs. Trump plays cat-and-mouse with the national press corps and continues to tweet like an Internet troll, complete with bad spelling. His advisers give contradictory accounts about personnel decisions. Qualified candidates are rejected in favor of loyalists. His choice for national security adviser is aligned with Vladimir Putin.

You can't make this stuff up. Or maybe you can. Paul Horner, the leading purveyor of fake news on Facebook, told The Post's Caitlin Dewey he was stunned by Americans' gullibility: "I mean, that's how Trump got elected. He just said whatever he wanted, and people believed everything."

But surely you can't fool all the people all the time.

Twitter: @Milbank

https://www.washingtonpost.com/opinions/trumps-fake-news-presidency/2016/11/18/72cc7b14-ad96-11e6-977a-1030f822fc35_story.html?utm_term=.76a8c474e007

7- At home , play this interactive game :

Factitious - a game that tests your news sense - "Can you tell real news from fake news?" (factitious.augamestudio.com)

http://factitious.augamestudio.com/#/

LES DEGRES DE CERTITUDE ET LES TEMPS

EXERCISES

1)Traduire en français.

-She may not have received our email.
……
-They must be having lunch. They are not connected !
……
-You must be over 18 to join this social networking site.
……



-It must be my brother, he calls every day.
……
…
-“I phoned you this morning” –Sorry, I must have been in the garden !
……
…
-I must have seen you somewhere before.
……
…
-He should have told you about it, before you leave !
……
…
-She may have posted a message on her Facebook page.
……
…

2)Choisissez MAY ou MAY HAVE et conjuguez le verbe qui suit comme il convient.

-He (arrive) tomorrow ……

-He (arrive) yesterday ……

-He (not / know his text) but he played the role beautifully
……
-I (laugh) at you sometimes, but I like you a lot
……
-I (laugh) at him in the past, and I regret it.
……

3)Réécrivez les phrases avec MAY + BASE VERBALE ou MAY + VERBE –ING OU MAY + HAVE + PART. PASSE ou MAY + HAVE BEEN + Verbe-ING

-Perhaps he is ill
→……
-Perhaps she will come tomorrow
→……
-Perhaps he is watching TV
→……..
-Perhaps he saw her yesterday
→……
-Perhaps they had an early breakfast
→……..
-Perhaps you were dreaming
→……
-Perhaps it doesn’t work
→……..
-Perhaps he didn’t hear you
→……
-Perhaps it was right
→……

3) Mettez les verbes donnés entre parentheses à la forme qui convient : BASE VERBALE ou BE –ING ou HAVE + PART.PASSE

-My computer does not work, there must (be)……..……..something wrong with it.

-As I switched on my computer, there was an explosion. There must (be)……..……..something wrong.



-He can't (surf) ……..……on the net, not at this time of night !

-I can't find my cell phone. I must (leave)……..it at the restaurant.

-I might (take)…….…… a break around Christmas.

-Where is Jane? She might (wait)……for you at the airport.

-I can hear noises in the baby's room. He must (be)……..……awake.

-He has not fully recovered *(récupéré)* yet. He may (not / enter)……..…….……the competition.

-I don't understand why he didn't come. He must (change)……..……his mind.



PROBABILITE / CERTITUDE et TEMPS

Sur quel(s) moment(s) portent ces probabilités ? Moment concerné

Complète le tableau. Traduction

-*They will come. They always come for Christmas.*

-*They might come, but it's not likely.*

-*They may buy more presents this year !*

-*They may be travelling at the moment.*

-*They may have missed the train. They haven't arrived yet !*

-*They must be late.*

-*They might have had an accident.*

-*They must have forgotten to call us on the way.*

FAKE NEWS

Extra reading :

“Welles Scares Nation”, *History.com*, 2009.

On Oct. 30th 1938, Orson] Welles introduced his radio play with a spoken introduction, followed by an announcer reading a weather report. […]

An announcer broke in to report that “Professor Farrell of the Mount Jenning Observatory” had detected explosions on the planet Mars. Then the dance music came back on, followed by another interruption in which listeners were informed that a large meteor had crashed into a farmer’s field in Grovers Mills, New Jersey.

Soon, an announcer was at the crash site describing a Martian emerging from a large metallic cylinder. “Good heavens,” he declared, “something’s wriggling out of the shadow like a gray snake. Now here’s another and another one and another one. They look like tentacles to me… I can see the thing’s body now. It’s large, large as a bear. It glistens like wet leather. But that face, it… it… ladies and gentlemen, it’s indescribable. I can hardly force myself to keep looking at it, it’s so awful. […]

Soon “Martian cylinders” landed in Chicago and St. Louis. The radio play was extremely realistic, with Welles employing sophisticated sound effects and his actors doing an excellent job portraying terrified announcers and other characters. An announcer reported that widespread panic had broken out in the vicinity of the landing sites, with thousands desperately trying to flee. In fact, that was not far from the truth.

Perhaps as many as a million radio listeners believed that a real Martian invasion was underway. Panic broke out across the country. In New Jersey, terrified civilians jammed highways seeking to escape the alien marauders. People begged police for gas masks to save them from the toxic gas and asked electric companies to turn off the power so that the Martians wouldn’t see their lights. One woman ran into an Indianapolis church where evening services were being held and yelled, “New York has been destroyed! It’s the end of the world! Go home and prepare to die!”

When news of the real-life panic leaked into the CBS studio, Welles went on the air as himself to remind listeners that it was just fiction. There were rumors that the show caused suicides, but none were ever confirmed. The Federal Communications Commission investigated the program but found no law was broken. Networks did agree to be more cautious in their programming in the future. Orson Welles feared that the controversy generated by War of the Worlds would ruin his career. In fact, the publicity helped land him a contract with a Hollywood studio, and in 1941 he directed, wrote, produced, and starred in Citizen Kane—a movie that many have called the greatest American film ever made.

https://orlandfreelibrary.wordpress.com/2013/10/31/welles-scares-nation-that-was-the-headline-on-this-day-in-history-oct-31-1938/

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=dVq2SQIwz5s